

Why Gen Z Is a Boardroom Issue Now

And what CEOs must unlearn to win in the next decade and beyond

FOR THE FIRST time in decades, India's corporate leadership is confronting a generation that cannot be won with speed, scale or storytelling alone. Generation Z, or Gen Z—those aged between 13 and 29—is not impatient; it moves with intent. It is not anti-brand; it is against tall promises. And it is not rejecting consumption; it is redesigning the conditions under which consumption earns trust.

Data collected during the first fortnight of December 2025, from an analysis of more than 4,300 GenZers across metros and Tier II cities, points to a clear conclusion. They are not asking firms to market better; they are asking them to build better. That is why Gen Z is no longer a marketing problem, it is a CEO question.

Most leadership teams still approach Gen Z as a youthful segment to be decoded through platforms, influencers and formats. That is dangerously incomplete. Gen Z's behaviour cuts across pricing logic, product architecture, credit models, experience design and capital allocation. This generation spends carefully, saves early and upgrades selectively. For instance, over 40% of GenZers already saves 20–40% of their income, even at an early stage of career, while 16% save more than



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40%, typical of older cohorts.

It prioritises quality over brand reputation, value over visibility, and flexibility over ownership. When asked what most influences purchase decisions, product quality ranks first for 43% of GenZers, consistently ahead of brand reputation (26%) or influencer recommendations (just 6%). This is a generation persuaded by substance.

In effect, Gen Z behaves less like a target audience and more like a risk committee, scrutinising claims, questioning value and delaying commitment until confidence is earned. Nearly 78% say they are either very likely or somewhat likely to switch brands if a better alternative appears.

One of the most persistent misreads about Gen Z is that it lacks aspiration. Gen Z aspires for career growth, financial security, home ownership and global travel. More than 50% say they aspire to buy both a home and a car. What has changed is timing. Big-ticket purchases are postponed, not abandoned. Premium brands are sampled, not rejected.

Even in luxury, nuance matters. Over 70% say they either occasionally or regularly buy premium brands, yet only a minority commits exclusively. The dominant behaviour is trial. Credit, too, is approached cautiously. One-third of GenZers say they never borrow for discretion-